

SMART TARTT

Features

Every so often a first-novelist leaps out of the fray and into the literary spotlight. But unlike the apocalyptic eighties generation, Donna Tartt recalls a more romantic tradition: a privately idiosyncratic T. S. Eliot freak with a southern-gothic past who this month publishes her hotly awaited highbrow chiller, *The Secret History*. JAMES KAPLAN reports

Donna Tartt, who is going to be very famous very soon—conceivably the moment you read this—also happens to be exceedingly small. Teeny, even. “I’m the exact same size as Lolita,” she says. “Do you remember that poem from the novel?” She recites.

*Wanted, wanted: Dolores Haze
Her dream-gray gaze never flinches.
Ninety pounds is all she weighs
With a height of sixty inches.*

We’re sitting over a country breakfast in Smitty’s, a homey café in Oxford, Mississippi—site of the university, Ole Miss, and hometown of another Mississippi writer, name of Faulkner. Who may have won a Nobel, but whose books

has already made with her first novel, *The Secret History*, published this month by Knopf. Tartt taps her Marlboro Gold on the ashtray. She is a kind of girl-boy-woman in her lineaments, with lunar-pale skin, spooky light-green eyes, a good-size triangular nose, a high, pixieish voice. With her Norma Desmond sunglasses propped on her dark bobbed hair, her striped boy’s shirt and shorts from Gap Kids (the only store whose ready-to-wear fits her), and her ever-present cigarette, she is, somehow, a character of her own fictive creation: a precocious sprite from a Cunard Line cruise ship, circa 1920-something. A Wise Child out of Salinger.

“I know a ton of poetry by heart,” Tartt says, when I comment on her recital of the Nabokov rhyme. It’s true. She has an alarming ability to simply break into passages, short or long, from her favorite writing. She quotes, freely and naturally, from Thomas Aquinas, Cardinal Newman, Buddha, and Plato—as well as David Byrne of Talking Heads and Jonathan Richman of the Modern Lovers. And many others.

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BY STELLA PATRICK. HAIR AND MAKEUP BY TONYE SUNDEN FOR PERRELLÉ



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Photograph by DEWEY NICKS

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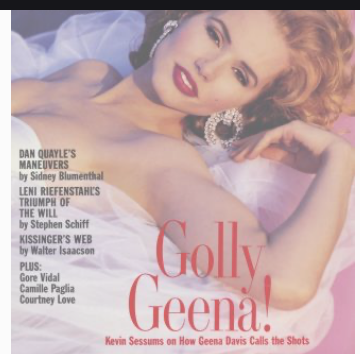
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“When I was a little kid, first thing I memorized were really long poems by



SWEET TARTT
Tartt and her dog, Pugs



DAN QUAYLE'S
MANUEVERS
by Sidney Blumenthal
LENI RIEFENSTAH'S
TRIUMPH OF
THE WILL
by Stephen Schiff
KISSINGER'S WEB
by Walter Isaacson
PLUS:
Core Vidal
Camille Paglia
Courtney Love

Golly
Geena!

Kevin Sexsuns on How Geena Davis Calls the Shots

VIEW FULL
ISSUE